

WHAT REMAINS OF ME

Annuscha Botes



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Dedication

*To my loving partner, who stood by me in my crazy idea of writing a novel while
homeschooling two of my kids and babysitting the other two.*

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Echo Q1

W e L o v e d h e r t o D e a t h

The rain had teeth.

Rain sliced through flesh like frozen razors, each drop hammering Angel's coffin like bullets counting down to hell. The sound was all wrong—too hollow, too empty. Like the cavity between her ribs where her heart used to slam against bone, the silence that followed her last, choking gasp.

Draven stayed back from the mourners, jaw clenched so tight his mouth flooded with copper. Even through the downpour, he could smell them—those lilies the Company sent. Manufactured blooms that had never tasted real earth or honest sunlight, perfect as everything else those bastards touched.

Perfect as they'd tried to make her.

The memory crashed over him like a sledgehammer—Angel pinned beneath him on the muddy training grounds, her body shaking as rain streamed down her face. Those green eyes wide open—not afraid of him, but of what she was becoming. *Don't let them change me*, she'd begged, fists shredding his shirt to ribbons. *Promise me, Draven.*

He'd wanted to devour that fear, drink it like communion wine. Had felt his Echo stirring at the salt-sweet taste of her tears when he'd licked them away. Even her terror was beautiful.

He'd failed her then. He was failing her now.

Company men moved through the pathetic crowd of mourners like shadows with silver thorn pins gleaming at their throats. Silent sentinels guarding secrets wrapped in mahogany and brass. They knew what festered in the darkness of their facilities. What grew in the deep places.

What was still growing.

Mickey shielded his sister Lisa under a torn umbrella, both of them hollow-cheeked ghosts with accusation burning in their eyes. The boy's gaze kept drifting back to Draven.

You were supposed to protect her.

Lisa pressed Angel's threadbare scarf to her face, breathing in the last whispers of her sister's scent. "She's not in there," the girl whispered, words nearly swallowed by wind. "Angel's not in that box. She's watching us."

If only you knew how right you are.

Steve approached, and Draven's chest locked up with something worse than hatred. Even now, he was devastatingly beautiful the way broken things sometimes are—rain streaming through golden hair, those perfect lips trembling with words that would destroy everything. Even shattered, Steve was so mesmerizing Draven wanted to break him completely.

The letter in Steve's hand dissolved, ink running like the tears he wouldn't shed. Those impossible green eyes swept the meager crowd before settling on the casket—on the lie they'd all gathered to bury.

"Angel Reyes was—" The name cracked something inside Steve's chest. He stopped, jaw working, before continuing with hard-won control. "She was everything they said she couldn't be. Perfect, even broken."

The confession hung in the air like a death rattle. Draven remembered those words—the same fucking words Steve had whispered as Angel died in their arms, her Echo fighting to bind her soul to flesh that was already cooling.

"She chose love over everything else," Steve continued, his control fracturing with each syllable. "Chose sacrifice over safety.

Chose—"His eyes found Draven through the rain, and there was no manipulation there now. Only devastation. Only the kind of hunger that ate men alive from the inside. "She chose who she loved, and she loved without reservation."

Like a disease, Draven snarled silently. *Like poison in the blood*.

"I tried to make her choose me," Steve's voice scraped raw now, bleeding truth. "God help me, I manipulated every situation, every moment. I thought if I could just be perfect enough, controlled enough—" He laughed, the sound like shattered glass in rain. "But she saw through it all. Saw the monster I'd become and chose the one who was honest about what he was."

The rain intensified, and Draven watched water cascade over Steve's flawless face like the tears he refused to cry. He wanted to take that perfect face and smash it against granite until it was as broken as the ruins inside.

"You were supposed to protect her." Mickey's voice cut through the downpour like a blade. The boy had stepped away from Lisa, rain streaming down his small face. "Both of you. She trusted you, and you let her die."

Steve flinched like he'd been struck but didn't retreat from the accusation burning in those young eyes. "Yes," he said simply. "We did."

The brutal honesty of it—the complete lack of excuses—hit Draven like a physical blow.

This was Steve stripped raw, vulnerable as an open wound. No smooth words, no manipulation. Just grief, pure and devastating.

And fuck if his suffering wasn't the most exquisite thing Draven had ever witnessed.